

COVER TO COVER

1 Samuel David and The Psalms

An overview of 1 Samuel, chapters 18–31 are much more than the story of David running from Saul.

This section is one of the greatest Messianic pictures in the entire Old Testament.

David is not merely a future king—he becomes the living prototype of the Messiah, while Saul gradually becomes a prototype of mankind's rebellion against God's chosen King.

We will do an overview that highlights the emotional and often overlooked themes...from chapter 18-31

1 Samuel 18

The Cost of God's Favor

Most people remember David's victory over Goliath.

But chapter 18 is actually about something far more dangerous:

What happens after the victory.

David receives everything most people dream about:

- national fame
- military success
- wealth
- marriage into royalty
- the love of the people

Ironically, every blessing becomes another reason Saul hates him.

David did nothing wrong.

He simply became the visible evidence that God's Spirit had departed from Saul.

Saul could not attack God...

so he attacked the one carrying God's favor.

This becomes one of Scripture's first pictures of how the religious establishment later treats Jesus.

Jonathan's covenant

Jonathan doesn't merely become David's friend.

He voluntarily surrenders:

- robe
- sword
- armor
- belt

These are royal symbols.

Jonathan is essentially acknowledging,

"God chose David instead of me."

This one of the greatest acts of humility in Scripture because Jonathan willingly lays down what he legally deserved.

Very few heirs to a throne have ever done that.

1 Samuel 19

Saul officially declares war

This chapter marks the point where Saul stops struggling privately.

Now his rebellion becomes public.

Jonathan cannot believe his father truly wants David dead.

Jonathan keeps believing Saul's violent words are temporary emotional outbursts rather than settled intentions.

Psalm 59

It is believed that David probably wrote Psalm 59 while Saul's assassins surrounded his house.

When you read these Psalms alongside the story that 1 Samuel is giving us, you are invited into David's emotions and heart in this moment.

Saul among the prophets

When Saul enters Samuel's prophetic community, God's Word becomes so powerful that even Saul's soldiers cannot continue their evil mission.

Under the Law holiness could spread through physical contact.

The Word became "contagious"

Obviously not literally contagious.

The picture is this:

Under the Law:

Holiness → transferred by contact with holy things.

God designated certain people, places, and objects as holy.

For example:

- The Tabernacle was holy.
- The altar was holy.
- Priestly garments were holy.
- Sacrificial meat became holy.
- The priests themselves were consecrated as holy.

Because these things belonged to God, **physical contact with them often communicated their holy status or required someone to be treated as holy.**

Examples include:

Exodus 29:37

"Whatever touches the altar shall become holy."

The altar itself did not magically make someone morally righteous. Instead, contact with the altar placed that object into God's sacred sphere.

Exodus 30:29

"Whatever touches them shall become holy."

This refers to the holy furnishings of the Tabernacle.

Leviticus 6:27

"Whatever touches its flesh shall become holy."

Here the meat of certain sacrifices transferred ceremonial holiness through touch.

In Samuel:

God's Spirit → overwhelms anyone who comes into His presence.

Notice the progression:

Saul comes intending murder.

↓

He encounters God's prophetic presence.

↓

His evil assignment completely stops.

↓

He begins declaring God's words instead.

The mission of murder cannot survive in God's presence.

Here, the spoken Word of God spiritually overcomes evil men without physical contact.

The truth itself becomes "contagious."

1 Samuel 20

Jonathan chooses covenant over bloodline

Jonathan is one of Scripture's greatest unsung heroes.

He chooses covenant over politics.

Family over kingdom would have been expected.

Instead Jonathan chooses God's will over family loyalty.

He knows David will replace him...
and still protects David.

1 Samuel 21

David eats the holy bread

David is not violating Torah.

The priests understand something greater is occurring.

Mercy never abolishes holiness.

Rather, holiness recognizes God's greater Kingdom purpose.

Jesus later appeals to this event because David becomes the pattern of the Messiah.

Goliath's sword

David receives Goliath's sword from the Tabernacle.

The weapon once intended to destroy God's servant...

becomes the weapon God preserves for him.

The enemy unknowingly provided David's future victory.

1 Samuel 22

The cave of Adullam

David's first followers arrive.

Notice who they are.

Not Israel's elite.

They are:

- distressed
- indebted
- bitter
-this mirrors Jesus.

The Kingdom begins with broken people.

Not polished people.

Nob is destroyed

Saul murders the priests.

This isn't merely violence.

It is the king declaring war against God's priesthood.

Only Abiathar escapes.

...David later becomes responsible for preserving the **true** priestly line.

1 Samuel 23

David keeps rescuing people

Even while hunted...

David continues protecting Israel.

Saul...

the king...

does not.

David performs the work of a king long before receiving the throne.

The anointing precedes the crown.

Jonathan's final visit

Jonathan strengthens David.

This is their last meeting.

No dramatic farewell.

No public recognition.

Only quiet covenant faithfulness.

1 Samuel 24

David refuses revenge

this is perhaps the greatest Messianic lesson.

David has every opportunity to kill Saul.

His own soldiers insist,

"God delivered him."

Bradford warns:

Not every opportunity comes from God.

Sometimes God tests hearts by allowing opportunities.

David understood timing belongs to God.

The Kingdom cannot be seized.

It must be received.

1 Samuel 25

Abigail

Abigail is one of Scripture's wisest women.

She prevents David from ruining his future.

David almost destroys his testimony through revenge.

God sends Abigail to save David...

not merely Nabal.

Even God's chosen leaders sometimes need correction.

Nabal

His name literally means "fool."

1 Samuel 26

David passes the same test again

Why repeat nearly the same story?

Because passing one test doesn't exempt us from future tests.

David again refuses to kill Saul.

Integrity becomes habit.

Not accident.

1 Samuel 27

David lives among the Philistines

This chapter surprises many readers.

David grows weary.

Fear affects his judgment.

Even great saints have moments where faith grows thin.

God remains faithful despite David's imperfect decisions.

That gives tremendous hope.

1 Samuel 28

Saul and the medium

Bradford rejects sensationalism.

The tragedy isn't primarily the séance.

The tragedy is that Saul waited until God stopped answering before becoming desperate.

Years of rebellion finally produced silence.

One of Bradford's repeated warnings:

Persistent disobedience eventually produces spiritual deafness.

1 Samuel 29

The Philistines reject David

David thinks he's trapped.

God quietly rescues him.

Bradford notes David probably doesn't even recognize God saving him.

Sometimes unanswered plans are God's greatest protection.

1 Samuel 30

Ziklag burns

Perhaps David's darkest day.

Everything is gone.

Families.

Homes.

Children.

Even David's own men want to stone him.

Bradford highlights one simple sentence:

"David strengthened himself in the LORD."

Nobody encouraged David.

Nobody prophesied over David.

Nobody rescued David.

He had learned how to find strength directly in God.

Bradford says mature faith eventually learns this lesson.

Sharing the spoil

David establishes a principle.

Those guarding supplies receive the same reward as those fighting.

Bradford sees this as a Kingdom principle.

Not everyone fights on the front lines.

But everyone shares in God's victory.

1 Samuel 31

Saul dies

Bradford sees profound sadness here.

Saul did not begin as a villain.

He began as God's ideal choice.

He had every opportunity.

Every advantage.

Yet little by little...

small compromises became complete rebellion.

Bradford repeatedly reminds listeners that nobody falls overnight.

Spiritual collapse is almost always incremental.

David versus Saul

Bradford says these final chapters intentionally place two kingdoms side by side.

Saul's Kingdom

- Fear
- Self-preservation
- Jealousy
- Political control
- Fleshly ambition
- External religion
- Declining anointing
- Grasping for power

David's Kingdom

- Waiting
- Covenant loyalty
- Mercy
- Humility
- Dependence upon God
- Repentance
- Hidden preparation
- Receiving rather than seizing the throne

David's greatest victories are not Goliath, military campaigns, or popularity.

According to Bradford, **David's greatest victories are the moments when he refuses to take what God has promised until God Himself gives it.**

That is why David becomes such a compelling foreshadowing of Christ. Jesus also refused to seize power through Satan's shortcuts, waited for the Father's timing, endured unjust suffering, showed mercy to His enemies, and ultimately received His Kingdom from God rather than grasping for it. Bradford sees this entire section of 1 Samuel as preparing readers to recognize the heart of the coming Messiah.

In 1 Samuel, we have learned about the prophet/judge...Samuel.

We've learned that the people asked for a king and Saul was the peoples choice.

We've met David...he is anointed King...while Saul continues to sit on the throne as king.

We learned last week, that Jonathan recognizes that David is the next king...1 Samuel 18.

David is brought into Saul's house and given status ...

Now Saul will begin to be jealous of David and will start his attempts to kill David.

Jonathan will protect David this whole time.

Saul and his three sons and armor bearer will die all on the same day...

When Saul dies, now David will be enthroned as the king...

PSALMS...there is something else going on during the book of 1 Samuel...David is writing some of his Psalms...

While studying the book of 1 Samuel, there is another book of the Bible that needs to be added in... the Book of Psalms:

During the events recorded in **1 Samuel (chapters 16–31)**, David almost certainly wrote a number of psalms. Some are identified by their inspired superscriptions (titles), while others are inferred from the historical setting. The superscriptions are part of the Hebrew text and provide the strongest evidence for connecting a psalm to a specific event.

Below is the chronological relationship between **1 Samuel** and the Psalms.

1 Samuel Event	Psalms(s)	Evidence
David anointed by Samuel (1 Sam. 16)	Possibly Psalm 8, 19, 23 (speculative)	No direct superscription. Traditional suggestions only.
David defeats Goliath (1 Sam. 17)	No canonical psalm	The Greek Septuagint includes Psalm 151 about Goliath, but it is not in the Hebrew canon.
Saul begins pursuing David (1 Sam. 19)	Psalm 59	"When Saul sent men to watch David's house in order to kill him." Directly references 1 Samuel 19.
David flees to Nob and then Gath (1 Sam. 21)	Psalm 34	Written after David "pretended to be insane before Achish." (Called Achish in Samuel.)
Same event in Gath	Psalm 56	"When the Philistines seized him in Gath."
David hides in Cave of Adullam (1 Sam. 22)	Psalm 57	"When he fled from Saul into the cave." Most connect this to Adullam.
Cave period	Psalm 142	"A Maskil of David. When he was in the cave." Could

(possibly Adullam or En Gedi)		fit either cave episode.
Doeg betrays David (1 Sam. 21–22)	Psalms 52	Superscription names Doeg the Edomite telling Saul.
Ziphites betray David (1 Sam. 23)	Psalms 54	Written "when the Ziphites went to Saul."
David spares Saul in the cave (1 Sam. 24)	Psalms 57 or 142	Some scholars prefer En Gedi instead of Adullam for these cave psalms.
Wilderness years	Psalms 63	"When he was in the wilderness of Judah." This fits either late 1 Samuel or early 2 Samuel. (Bible Study Tools)

Psalms that are almost certainly from 1 Samuel

These have explicit historical titles:

- Psalm 34 — Escape from Achish after pretending madness (1 Samuel 21)
- Psalm 52 — Doeg's betrayal (1 Samuel 22)
- Psalm 54 — Betrayal by the Ziphites (1 Samuel 23)
- Psalm 56 — Captured in Gath (1 Samuel 21)
- Psalm 57 — In the cave while fleeing Saul
- Psalm 59 — Saul's men surrounded David's house (1 Samuel 19)
- Psalm 142 — Prayer from the cave

These are the seven psalms that virtually every conservative chronology places during the events of **1 Samuel** because their superscriptions point directly to those historical events.

Psalms that may also belong to the 1 Samuel period

Many commentators—including those whose work aligns with the historical-redemptive approach of teachers like **Tom Bradford**—also suggest these were likely written during David's years as a shepherd or fugitive, although there is no inspired superscription identifying the occasion:

- Psalm 23
- Psalm 7
- Psalm 11
- Psalm 17
- Psalm 27
- Psalm 31
- Psalm 35
- Psalm 64

These assignments are based on internal themes (flight from enemies, wilderness imagery, trust during persecution) rather than explicit historical titles, so scholars differ.

A valuable teaching observation

One of the remarkable features of studying **1 Samuel** alongside the Psalms is that the narrative and David's worship life can be read together. For example:

- **Read 1 Samuel 19, then Psalm 59.**
- **Read 1 Samuel 21, then Psalms 34 and 56.**
- **Read 1 Samuel 22, then Psalm 52.**
- **Read 1 Samuel 23, then Psalm 54.**
- **Read 1 Samuel 24, then Psalms 57 and 142.**

This allows you to see not only **what happened to David**, but also **what David was praying, feeling, and declaring to God while those events were unfolding**, providing a rich devotional and theological companion to the historical narrative.